In Juhu, Mumbai—pin code 400 049—stand two edifices that must count as the mecca of Indian cinema. The structures themselves inspire no great awe, betray no special aura beyond what any bungalow in an upmarket neighbourhood may be accused of exuding. But like with any shrine, it's about who resides within. Generations of filmgoers have been so enamoured of the man—so filled by a strange energy at his mere appearance on that screen on which their desires are projected—that he seems to approach a numinous stature. Here, on the road outside, vehicles slow down so passengers can quickly take photos, even if it is just a shot of the wooden gate. Pedestrians refresh themselves with water from a giant earthen vessel and prayers begin for a miracle sighting. Vigilant safari-clad men blow their shrill whistles to ensure there's no crowding. It's pointless. There's always one, especially in the evenings. From 1976 to 2000s, this scene used to unfold at Prateeksha, now it is Jalsa. There's also Janak nearby, a kind of workspace, which has escaped attention. Not surprising perhaps, because it's at the primary abode that the devout feel the magic of nearness. The hero they have come to worship...He Lives Here. And his name is Amitabh Bachchan.

It's a Sunday evening, a day when Bachchan, if he's in town and in the mood, is known to greet and wave at his fans. A quick sampling of the crowd reveals something about the man—the way his force-field has overflowed the usual embankments of space and time. There are fans of all age groups. And the catchment area is also pan-national, not usual for a Hindi film personality. Jessy and Smita, a lawyer and a teacher, respectively, are from Kerala. They have ditched their friends in Juhu beach in the hope of sighting the man they adored in *Piku*. "There's something very interesting about him," says Jessy, as she makes her way to Prateeksha from Jalsa. Standing across the road from them is Vikas Singh, a doctor from Patna, who refers to Bachchan as a "superhero". Singh's words are tinged with awe as he shares his long list of favourite Bachchan films. "He is a league apart," he says. "So many have gone, but he is still performing."

The 'still' is pertinent because Bachchan turns 80 on October 11. He made his feature film debut at the age of 27. A different epoch: the Beatles were still playing, a fledgling Doordarshan had not even reached Bombay, and women in Hindi films were still cycling to picnics with their hair in beehive buns, singing pretty songs. Fifty-three years later, all that is water down the bridge, but he is 'still' on top of his game. So much so that he puts far younger peers to shame with his sheer, jaw-dropping volume of work, as with his still-undimmed work ethic.

But even a phenomenon has to start somewhere. A quiet, dignified entry in a film called *Saat Hindustani*